Captain Rajeev Bahuguna was seriously injured during this operation, when a stray splinter severed his windpipe and lodged in his spine, paralysing him from the waist down. He was the only casualty suffered by the security forces, contrary to reports appearing in many local dailies. For his role in the operation, he was later awarded the Sena Medal (Gallantry). Rajeev spent months and years in rehabilitation in Pune, never losing hope and always maintaining his cheerful demeanour. I visited him often, as did my mother, in the Military Hospital, Kirkee, Pune, keeping him motivated. He later married Capt Lucy, the nurse who used to care for him, and they were blessed with a daughter, Riddhima, in 2006. The Army wanted to board him out on medical grounds, but we fought his case for retention with the full support of the GOC, CIF (K), initially Maj Gen Dalbir Singh (PARA) followed by Maj Gen S Yadav (RAJ RIF). The Army never abandons anyone.

Not all stories had a happy ending. On one occasion, an area domination patrol (ADP), while on the banks of the Hokar Sar, saw some suspicious movement in the early morning mist. There were two or three people in a small boat, armed with weapons. The ADP challenged the unidentified group who, save for one person, dived into the icy waters, whereupon the party opened fire. The Company Commander radioed me and I immediately left for the spot. A search of the area after daybreak revealed that the boatman, who had his back to the ADP, had died. The SHO from the nearest police station was called for, who carried out his own investigation, interacting with the locals. It transpired that a few youths had gone poaching in the Hokar Sar armed with small calibre rifles and shotguns. On being challenged, they had escaped by jumping into the water and had since returned to their homes, much to the relief of their parents. The boatman was a deaf-mute from the nearby village,

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